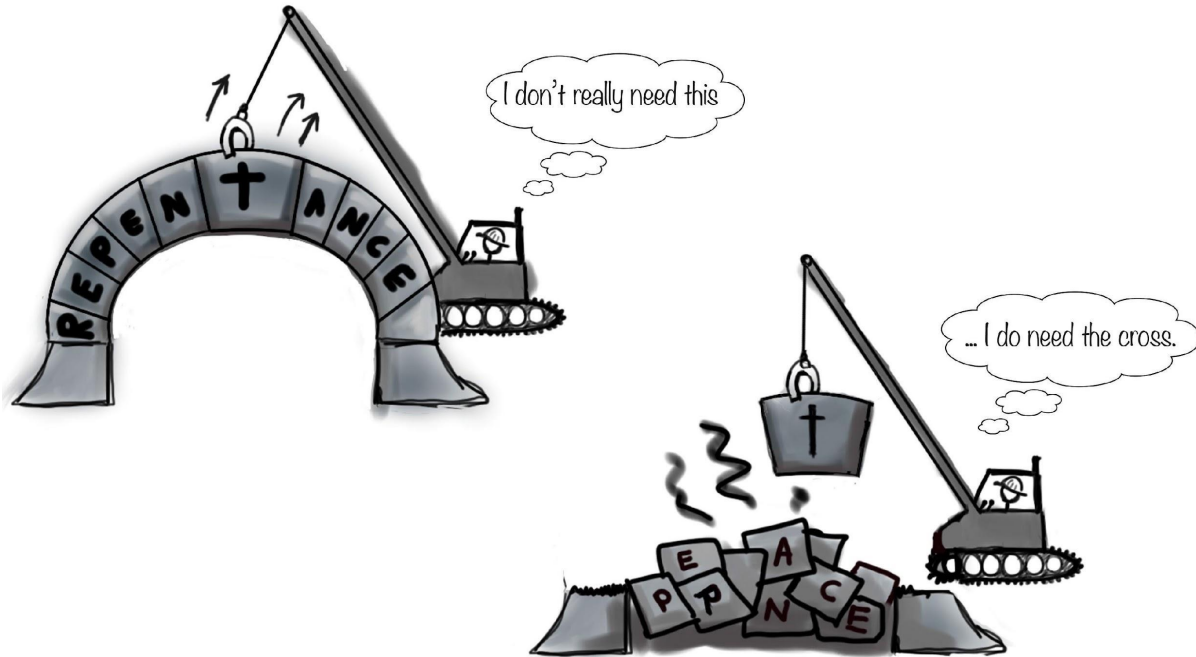


SESSION 2C

WE DON'T UNDERSTAND REPENTANCE



MISCONCEPTIONS ABOUT REPENTANCE: IT'S GLOOMY!

Some people regard repentance as necessarily gloomy. Of course, repentance is serious, and involves sorrow. If the transgression is grave, or has caused hurt and damage, then it's even more so. Yet, the Bible promises that repentance leads to times of refreshing even in the midst of such sorrow.



ACTS 3:19–20 (ESV)

¹⁹ Repent therefore, and turn back, that your sins may be blotted out,

²⁰ that times of refreshing may come from the presence of the Lord ...

Apostle Peter promised that after repenting, his listeners could expect “times of refreshing” to come from the Lord. This is one of the signs of gospel-centered repentance. Because repentance restores our fellowship with God, there is naturally a joy that comes from that renewed bond.

Repentance revives our closeness with God. It is not a gloomy, sad affair. As you repent, you experience a blow to your ego, but you realize that your ego is a tyrant that needs to die. As you admit your wrong and seek forgiveness, your ego dies, and a child-like sweetness enters your soul as the toxic fangs of your pride retract. It is restorative and refreshing.

Have you experienced admitting your wrong to a friend, saying sorry and then experiencing “times of refreshing” in your relationship afterwards?

How have you experienced a similar thing with God?**MISCONCEPTIONS ABOUT REPENTANCE: IT'S PURELY NEGATIVE!**

Repentance is anything but negative. The promise of God's forgiveness through the cross—the gospel, in other words—is a positive, affirmative, open invitation for all self-acknowledged sinners to be restored and made right. It leads to freedom from hiding.

The gospel, applied to our hearts every day, frees us to be brutally honest with ourselves and with God. The assurance of His total forgiveness of our sins through the blood of Christ means we don't have to play defensive games anymore. We don't have to rationalize and excuse our sins. We can say we told a lie instead of saying we exaggerated, a bit. We can admit an unforgiving spirit instead of continuing to blame our parents for our emotional distress.

We can call sin exactly what it is, regardless of how ugly and shameful it may be, because we know that Jesus bore that sin in His body on the cross. With the assurance of total forgiveness through Christ, we have no reason to hide from our sins anymore. ¹

- Jerry Bridges, *Discipline of Grace*

The cross of Jesus not only invites us to come clean about our sins, but the experience of repentance deepens our appreciation of it. When we repent, we realize that the cross of Jesus reaches deeper than we had thought. We realize our need for his atoning sacrifice was direr than we had thought. Whereas before, we had a certain view of our sinfulness, as we repent, we realize that we had underestimated our depravity, and therefore underappreciated God's grace to us through the cross. Through bringing our sins to the cross and trusting in the power of the cross to cleanse us again and again, the power and glory of the cross grows in our hearts, and we experience a greater security in God's grace. This is something of the times of refreshing that Acts 3 speaks about.

MISCONCEPTIONS ABOUT REPENTANCE: SHOULD BE DONE RARELY!

It should be done rarely since it's so costly. Jesus told Peter that this is one of the things that binds them together.

**JOHN 13:1-8 (ESV)**

¹ Now before the Feast of the Passover, when Jesus knew that his hour had come to depart out of this world to the Father, having loved his own who were in the world, he loved them to the end. ² During supper, when the devil had already put it into the heart of Judas Iscariot, Simon's son, to betray him, ³ Jesus, knowing that the Father had given all things into his hands, and that he had come from God and was going back to God, ⁴ rose from supper. He laid aside his outer garments, and taking a towel, tied it around his waist. ⁵ Then he poured water into a basin and began to wash the disciples' feet and to wipe them with the towel that was wrapped around him. ⁶ He came to Simon Peter, who said to him, "Lord, do you wash my feet?" ⁷ Jesus answered him, "What I am doing you do not understand now, but afterward you will understand." ⁸ Peter said to him, "You shall never wash my feet." Jesus answered him, "If I do not wash you, you have no share with me."

¹ Bridges, Jerry. *The Discipline of Grace*. Colorado Springs, Colorado: NavPress. 1994. pp. 22-23.

As Jesus is washing the disciples' feet, he is not doing it in disgust or out of a spiteful attitude of wanting to teach them a lesson by putting them in the awkward position of having their master wash their feet. Something more is going on here. When Peter objects (because this is precisely how he is interpreting Jesus' actions), Jesus tells him that he will understand "afterwards." The "afterwards" refers to the post-cross perspective. In other words, Jesus' washing of their feet is symbolic of Jesus' blood washing away their sins.

So when Peter says, "you shall never wash my feet," Jesus' response sounds startlingly sharp at first: "If I do not wash you, you have no share in me." But this is literally true. Jesus came for only one reason: to die to wash away our sins. If we keep refusing to show him our feet because they smell and are dirty, Jesus must say to us, "If I do not wash the dirtiest part of you, you and I have nothing to do with each other."

Jesus wants to wash you. That's what he came to do. In some ways, avoiding repentance is spurning Jesus himself. Presenting your best parts, and pretending that you are already clean is frustrating and devaluing his love for you.

Think about feet, especially ones wearing sandals while traveling the dirt roads of ancient Palestine. That's what Jesus uses to illustrate this powerful point: we need daily washing, and he does not mind doing it. In fact, he did it out of love (v. 1). So don't be shy or reluctant to bring your worst, most shameful self to him daily.

MISCONCEPTIONS ABOUT REPENTANCE: IT SHOULD LEAD TO INSTANT CHANGE!

This is true enough. The Greek word for repentance, *metanoia*, means change of mind. If you repent, then you do end up with a change of mind about your sin. You hate your sin, and love the one who forgives you. However, it may take time—sometimes a lot of time—for the *metanoia* to lead to radical change in behavior.

The misconception about repentance involved here may be something like: "If I repented, then I should not commit that sin anymore." This view may contain the idea of repentance as a method of self-improvement. There are a lot of flaws in us that cause us problems. As we get older, these problems become greater, especially as they reach out and burn others, e.g., having a bad temper. We may get frustrated that we seem to be in a cycle of erupting temper, hurting someone, repenting, and resolving not to do it again, only to find ourselves losing our temper yet again.

Repentance may not immediately lead to visible change. However, there is an inner change going on. It leads you to humility. It leads you to a sense of your own brokenness. And this is a good place to be, since it leads you to a greater dependence on the cross of Jesus.

**” To be broken is the beginning of revival.
It is painful, it is humiliating, but it is the only way. ²**

– Roy Hession, *Calvary Road*

The Lord Jesus cannot live in us fully and reveal Himself through us until the proud self within us is broken. This simply means that the hard unyielding self, which justifies itself, wants its own way, stands up for its rights, and seeks its own glory, at last bows its head to God's will, admits it's wrong, gives up its own way to Jesus, surrenders its rights and discards its own glory...In other words, it is dying to self and self-attitudes. ³

- Roy Hession, *Calvary Road*

In the end, maybe the biggest transformation repentance brings is not necessarily a triumph over sin, and a powerful life of saintliness, but an enduring spirit of contrition and humility before God and before our fellow man.

² Roy Hession, *Calvary Road*. London: Christian Literature Crusade. 2011. p. 21.

³ Roy Hession, *Calvary Road*. London: Christian Literature Crusade. 2011. p. 22.



ISAIAH 57:15 (ESV)

¹⁵ For thus says the One who is high and lifted up,
who inhabits eternity, whose name is Holy:
“I dwell in the high and holy place,
and also with him who is of a contrite and lowly spirit,
to revive the spirit of the lowly,
and to revive the heart of the contrite.”

PSALM 51:17 (ESV)

¹⁷ The sacrifices of God are a broken spirit;
a broken and contrite heart, O God, you will not despise.

Pause here to pray if the Holy Spirit is convicting you of some sin that you need to repent of. Then, pray a prayer expressing your gratitude towards God for the gift of repentance that is made possible through the cross of Jesus.

REPENT AND BELIEVE



MARK 1:14-15 (ESV)

¹⁴ Now after John was arrested, Jesus came into Galilee, proclaiming the gospel of God, ¹⁵ and saying, “The time is fulfilled, and the kingdom of God is at hand; repent and believe in the gospel.”

The above passage records the first words of Jesus’ public ministry. “Repent and believe the gospel,” Jesus said. Note that Jesus did not say just repent. He said, “Repent and believe the gospel.”

Underneath all our sins is a refusal of the gospel. Therefore any repentance must complete the loop by starting with acknowledging and confessing the sin, and ending with a fuller embracing of the gospel. Some Christians have called this “the sin beneath the sin.” I.e., in all our sins, there is a failure to believe the gospel. So whatever the sin you are repenting of, you also need to uncover the disbelief of the gospel that lies beneath that sin, and pray over and meditate over the gospel until you can reaffirm it at a deeper level. In this way the gospel will become more deeply rooted in your life.

For example, if you have a hard time taking legitimate criticism of your work, and respond in anger or get overly dramatic about it, then you need to repent for the dishonesty in fighting off criticism, the temper that may have erupted against someone because of it, or the vindictive or vicious thoughts you may have harbored against the person who criticized you. That’s all at the manifested level of your sinful response to just criticism.

But what else is going on? What is the sin beneath this sin? In other words, what is it about the gospel that you are rejecting when you respond this way?

Maybe you are deeply insecure, and have built up your work competence as a pseudo-god, a man-made gospel that will deliver you. And when your work was criticized, it threatened the very ground of your being and significance. But the gospel secures your being as a child of God. The gospel says you are so beloved that Jesus died to forgive you and adopt you into his family, where you have eternal significance. Why are you looking to some precarious hold you have on competence in your work to save you when Jesus already has? Why are you trying to build your significance with your own efforts at competence, when Jesus already told you that you are eternally significant? And why do you recoil at criticism when the cross already criticizes you far more devastatingly than any person can? After all, the cross tells you that your sins were so horrific that it took the sinless Son of God to die on a cross to forgive you. It also tells you that you are so loved that he did so willingly.

Thus the sin of reacting with hostility at criticism of your work arises from a deeper source to which the gospel must now be applied.

“Repent and believe the gospel,” Jesus said. When we repent, we need to also grab a fresh hold of the gospel in a deeper way.

PITFALLS TO AVOID



Why would not understanding the role of repentance in a believer's life lead to the following?

➤ **Defensiveness**

➤ **Avoidance of truth**

